

Hello Papa, I am good. How are you? Yes, I had dinner. What about you? Yes, I understand I couldn't call you for the last two weeks because of some urgent and important deliverables at work. Anything, Papa? Then bye, Papa, I have some official work.

See only 31 seconds. This is how I used to talk with my father.

Today, I want to ask you three important questions.

So, my first question is targeted at the leftmost row: How many of you reach out to YouTube if you want to learn a new recipe?

Now, the middle rows: How many of you reach out to YouTube for motivational speeches or inspirational videos when you feel low?

And finally, the rightmost row: How many of you turn to AI tools when you need advice, guidance, or opinions about something?

Hold onto your curiosity—I will come back to these questions later.

Toastmaster of the Day, fellow Toastmasters, and guests,

Recently, there was a series of incidents in my life that inspired me to make some changes within myself. So today, I am standing here to communicate those changes to you so that you would understand, validate, and perhaps incorporate them into your own lives.

Currently, I work as a team leader at a multinational technology company. For the last three years, I have been receiving “exceeds expectations” in my performance appraisals. For those who are not familiar with corporate terminology, “exceeds expectations” means scoring 4 out of 5 in performance evaluations. However, my promotion was overdue, so to ensure it this time, I decided to have a one-on-one meeting with my manager to discuss my aspirations. My manager's response wasn't what I hoped for. He said, “Somnath, promotions don't happen just because you ask for them. They happen only when leadership sees something special in you.”

That meeting left me feeling discouraged. I started worrying about my future because I wanted to figure out my next step. Naturally, like many of you, I turned to AI tools for advice. I got responses like, “Stay positive and patient” or “Articulate your achievements with seniors.” But honestly, none of it felt helpful.

So, one fine day, I called my father and told him everything. What he said hit me hard: “Maybe you’re perfect for your current role, but not for the next one. You need to show them that you’re capable of doing more than what you are currently doing.” He insisted that I upskill myself.

I realized he was right. I decided to opt for online courses, but I struggled to complete them because of my busy schedule. I thought I needed to work on time management. For that, I even tried time management techniques like the Pomodoro Technique and the Eisenhower Matrix from AI tools, but they didn’t work for me.

Discouraged, I called my father again. I told him about my struggles, and he then said, “Why not take a leave for upskilling?” I replied, “You are right, Papa, but I am not sure my organization would agree to that.” He said, “If you try genuinely, they won’t deny it.” I put in a request for three months of leave. Initially, they were reluctant, but I persisted. Finally, they approved my leave for three months next year, and that too with full pay. I am sure I would never have thought of taking a sabbatical leave if I hadn’t talked to my father.

Here’s what I learned: Both times, my father gave me unique, out-of-the-box advice. That wouldn’t have been possible with the internet. Here, I made a change in my approach. Before reaching directly to the internet, I now first reach out to someone who might have an answer. This way, I get a reason to call that person, and in the end, my personal bond with them gets stronger. What I see today is that everyone can get everything on the internet, so we don’t have a reason to call someone anymore.

Now in a conclusion I want to communicate a change in you, coming back to my initial questions:

Before you search for a recipe on YouTube, call your mother or mother-in-law instead. A YouTuber’s recipe might suggest ingredients you don’t have, but your mother will always recommend ones already in your kitchen because she knows your context.

When you feel low and want real uplifting, before browsing videos, you can call a family member or close friend.

When you need advice, guidance, or opinions, before querying an AI tool, try connecting with your colleagues, close friends, or Toastmasters.